

Friends of Beaver Creek State Park



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Beaver & Sandy Canal Lock #36

Ten years of planning, fundraising and actual reconstruction of Sandy & Beaver Canal Lock #36 entered its final phase in May Of 1991.

Ground was broken in August of 1988 to begin the restoration. The Lock would become a model to show how canal boats were once raised and lowered in the waterway. When complete, the lock would have cantilevered beam gates that open and close.

Floyd Lower was the first chairman of the restoration project, followed by Jack Lanam and John Wattenbarger. Pioneer Craft Days (now called Harvest Days), held each October at Beaver Creek State Park was the main fund raiser for the project.

Some of the wood used was provided by the Ohio Department of Natural Resources and was cut in a sawmill at Malabar Farm State Park. Canal stones were brought in from Fredericktown that were originally part of Lock #47 of the canal. Hardware for the gates was recovered from Lost Lock (Lock #50) and some were made in the Pioneer Village's Blacksmith Shop by blacksmith Woody Harman.

The gates were fabricated and assembled at Beaver Creek State Park by Christian & Son Timber framers during a workshop in early May of

1991. Dressed in clothing of the, 1800's, the timber framers constructed the gates utilizing hand tools of that era. The finished gates were hung on May 19, 1991. Each gate weighs and estimated 3 1/2 tons.

The canal era in Ohio began with the construction of the Ohio-Erie Canal in 1825. It connected the Ohio River at Portsmouth with Lake Erie at Cleveland. Several "feeder" canals were later built connecting with this important waterway to access the larger markets and promote the economic development along the waterway. The Sandy & Beaver Canal was one of these "feeder" canals, but unlike the others that received state funds, was privately financed through the sale of stock.



A lawyer and community leader of New Lisbon, Ohio, named Elderkin Potter, originated the idea of connecting the Ohio River at Glasgow, Pennsylvania with the Ohio-Erie Canal at Bolivar, Ohio by means of a canal using the

watersheds of the Sandy and Little Beaver Creeks. He had the support of many local businessmen, including Benjamin Hanna, Dr. George McCook, C. Hostetter and David Beggs. The Sandy & Beaver Canal Company was incorporated in 1828 and construction began in November 1834. Financial problems prevented its completion until January, 1848 by which time the railroads had already begun to have an impact on transportation needs. The canal was operated with moderate success for approximately four years.

The end came in the spring of 1852 when the Cold Run Dam broke just outside of New Lisbon causing extensive property damage, as well as

ruining a large section of the canal. The canal company went broke trying to settle the resulting lawsuits.

Some notable engineering feats were accomplished during the canal construction of two tunnels near Dungannon, Ohio. The Big Tunnel, 1060 yards long, was blasted out of rock and is the longest of all canal tunnels in America. The smaller tunnel, 300 yards long, was excavated through hard shale and a vein of coal. West Fork Canal Reservoir (Guilford Lake) was built to supply water for the canal.

Some of the finest masonry in canal lock construction can be seen in Beaver Creek State Park at Lusk Lock and between Gaston's Mill and Sprucevale.

Canal Statistics:

- Length: 73.5 miles
- Dams 30
- Locks: 90 Lift Locks (15' x 90' chambers)
- Tunnels: Two 1060 yards and 399 yards
- Aqueducts: 1 (wood) across Tuscarawas River
- Lockage: Approximately 685'
- Average Lift of Locks: 7.5 feet





Text from; Lock No. 36 Dedication Ceremony,
Beaver Creek State Park, August 17, 1991, 1:00
P.M., The Columbiana County Historical Society,
Forest and Parks Council and Sandy Beaver Canal
Association.

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Pioneer Village Photo by Dennis Smith

